upset was the Padshah at the mullahs' poor defence of Islam. Father Pereira taught Akbar a few words of Portuguese, one of which was the name of Jesus, which Akbar then took great pleasure in repeating aloud to himself in his palace.

It was in this spirit that Akbar's ambassador, Abdullah, was sent to the Jesuits in Goa where he was received by a number of Portuguese noblemen. Dressed in their finest robes and accompanied by a cavalcade of swishing horses, Abdullah was taken to the tomb of St Francis Xavier, a Catholic missionary and co-founder of the Society of Jesus, where the Mughal party removed their shoes respectfully and paid homage. A group of three Jesuits —Rudolf Acquaviva, the Spaniard Anthony Monserrate, and Henriques, a Muslim convert 'of great piety but of very slight learning', but fluent in Persian— was appointed to travel to the court of the 'Great Mogul'. 'I am writing to ask your prayers,' wrote Acquaviva earnestly to his uncle Father Claude Acquaviva, also a Jesuit. 'For we need greatly God's help, as we are being sent "like men appointed to death," into the midst of Muhammadans, whose word is always to be distrusted.' Nonetheless, Acquaviva reassured his uncle, 'we go…filled with a joy such as I have never felt before, because there is a chance of suffering something for Christ our Lord… And if we are to shed our blood for love of Him, a thing very possible in such an expedition, then shall we be truly blessed.' So with exaltation in their hearts and a Persian grammar book in their hands, the three Jesuits travelled to Fatehpur Sikri accompanied by an escort of twelve Mughal horsemen. They crossed plains 'covered with cactus, with palms, and banyan trees'. They travelled past mango trees in blossom, and fields of poppy, and flax, and noticed the frequent wells and stone tables built for the ease of pilgrims by Hindu citizens.

Travel, for the Hindu population, was an essential part of life. Pilgrimages were as much part of the texture of their lives as fasts, vows, and religious ceremonies. Very often, wealthy men from cities would send out invitations to their friends to join them on particularly redoubtable pilgrimages. The highways, though much more secure than earlier, could still be highly dangerous. Banarsi Das, a trader from Agra, once saved himself through his quick wit, pretending to be a Brahmin and reciting Sanskrit slokas and blessing the robbers so that they were either too ashamed or too fearful to rob the 'high caste' traveller. Akbar had begun